

GNU Linux Mint 17.3: The Friendly Distro



Linux Mint strives to be an elegant, modern, easy-to-use Linux distro. Based on Ubuntu and Debian, it tries to overcome the shortcomings of Ubuntu by packing in some proprietary software. The author takes the reader through the process of installing Linux Mint and gives a first hand account of how he has configured his own system.

Some time ago, an article titled “The free software at work” was published in *Byte* magazine (see Reference 1). In this four-page article, the author discusses GNU Linux and some applications, making some interesting comments mainly about their use in a research environment (at that time, the author was systems administrator in a university’s physics department). The first figure, in the article, shows GV (the PDF and PS viewer), LyX and the text editor Jed, all under KDE. The second figure shows a table and a graph made with StarOffice. Finally, the last figure shows Netscape and a terminal window opened under the FVWM desktop environment (I’m not too sure about this though, since the article appeared many years ago). So I decided to give Linux a chance, because the author was very optimistic, on the off chance that what he’d written was indeed true.

The next step involved choosing a distro — the first was Red Hat 5.0, and then SuSE from the version 5.3 (with Applixware Office 5.0) to the version 10.0. For the last few years, my preferred distro has been Mint, because I like to

have a distro that’s easy to install and to configure, and has almost all the software I need installed by default, in order to have a completely functioning system in a short span of time. In the past, I have mainly used GNOME and, sometimes, KDE. I’m not a big fan of GNOME’s transition to version 3 and KDE’s move to the Akonadi technology, because I like to have a desktop environment which is reasonably light, fast and easy to back up; so my choice is Xfce. This article is based on GNU Linux Mint 17.3 Xfce 32 bit ‘Rosa’.

The article presents some basic customisations of the desktop environment, and information about the installation and configuration of a few daily-used applications, with the help of the terminal window. Please note that the following are only examples because a lot of other ways are possible.

Settings and systems managers

Figure 1 shows the *Settings manager* with a yellow background, for the following options:

- The *Appearance* option, as suggested by the name, is to